



main four populated islands are clustered together. The temperature throughout the seasons on the islands tends to remain at approx 80°F (27°C) but in May, June, and November typhoons strike, causing huge

storms. Over hundreds of years various people, such as traders and missionaries, have settled on these islands, but the Yapese have always clung with determination to their original customs and traditions.

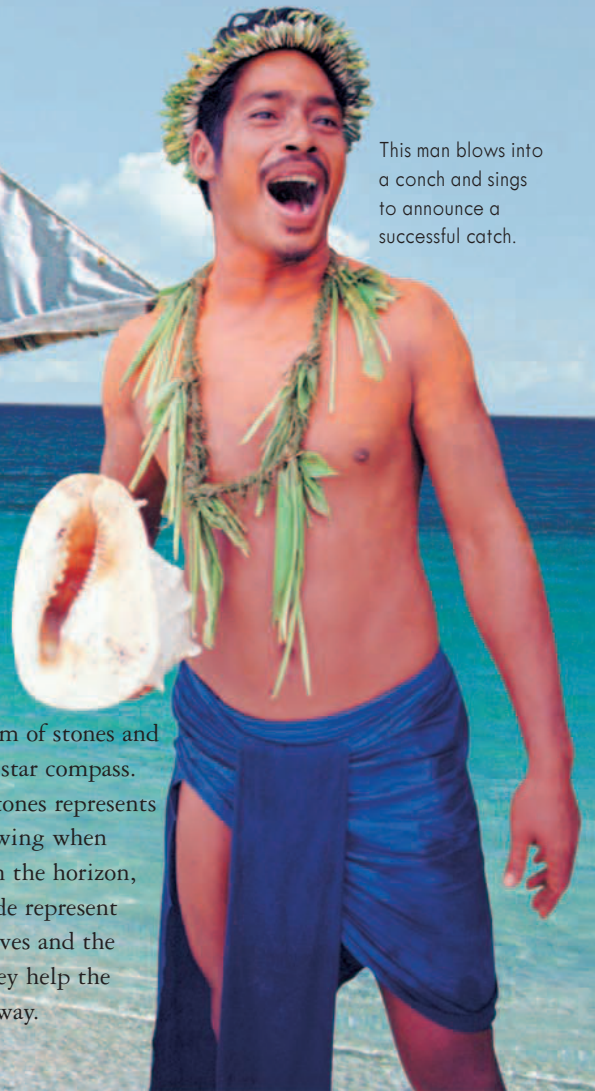
The coins have holes in the center so they can be carried. Two people are needed to carry each coin.



STONE CURRENCY

Yap coins are the biggest in the world. They are round chunks of stone that range from 1 ft (0.3 m) to 12 ft (3.5 m) tall. But the stone does not come from the Yap Islands. It comes from volcanic islands 300 miles (550 km) away. Over hundreds of years, Yapese sailors have risked their lives to bring back the stones in outrigger canoes.

This man blows into a conch and sings to announce a successful catch.



STAR COMPASS

This simple diagram of stones and leaves is actually a star compass. The outer rim of stones represents constellations, showing when they rise and set on the horizon, and the leaves inside represent the swell of the waves and the canoe. Together they help the navigator find his way.